SMALL BUSINESS BASICS · CANADA

WCB Basics for Nova Scotia Employers

Registration, assessments, injuries, and return to work, explained in plain language

A plain-language guide for small-business owners in Nova Scotia

First edition · November 2026

WCB Basics for Nova Scotia Employers — Registration, assessments, injuries, and return to work, explained in plain language

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Important. This guide is general information for Canadian small-business owners. It is not legal, tax, accounting, or financial advice, and it does not create a professional relationship of any kind. Rules, rates, forms, and software features change. Before you act, check the official source named in the guide and, where the stakes are real, talk to a qualified professional who knows your situation.

This guide is independent and is not affiliated with, sponsored by, or endorsed by the Workers' Compensation Board of Nova Scotia. Coverage rules, rates, and reporting deadlines are set by WCB Nova Scotia and can change, so confirm anything you plan to act on at wcb.ns.ca.

No result is promised. How useful any idea in this guide turns out to be depends on your business, your customers, your market, and how you apply it.

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Before you start

This guide is for small-business owners in Nova Scotia who have hired, or are about to hire, their first few workers. Maybe you run a cleaning company in Truro, a landscaping crew in Bridgewater, a café in Antigonish, or a small renovation business in Dartmouth. You have heard that you might need "WCB," and you want to understand what that means without wading through policy manuals.

Workers' compensation is run separately in each province. Everything here is about the Workers' Compensation Board of Nova Scotia (WCB Nova Scotia). If you also have workers in another province, that province has its own board and its own rules.

What this guide covers. The chapters explain what WCB Nova Scotia is and how it differs from workplace safety enforcement; how to work out whether you need to register; coverage for owners and contractors; how assessments (premiums) work in concept; reporting payroll; what to do, step by step, when a worker gets hurt; return to work; simple injury prevention; and the records to keep. Near the end you will find copy-ready worksheets, checklists, and forms.

The important part: this is not legal advice. This guide is general information. It is not legal advice, and it does not replace WCB Nova Scotia's own guidance. WCB decides whether your business must register, how it is classified, what you pay, and how a claim is handled. Rules, rates, forms, and deadlines change, sometimes from one year to the next.

You will see short reminders at points where you are close to a real decision. When you reach one, stop and confirm with WCB Nova Scotia (wcb.ns.ca) before you act. For questions about your legal obligations, a lawyer who works with employers can help. For payroll and bookkeeping, an accountant or bookkeeper can help.

> **NOTE**
>
> This guide is independent. It is not written, reviewed, or endorsed by WCB Nova Scotia or the Province of Nova Scotia. The worksheets help you gather information before you call WCB. They do not answer the question for you.

How WCB Nova Scotia works

The no-fault trade-off

WCB Nova Scotia provides workplace injury insurance for employers and workers in the province. It is “no-fault” insurance. When a covered worker is hurt on the job, the question is not “whose fault was it?” The question is “did this injury happen because of work?” If it did, the worker can receive benefits, such as wage-loss benefits and help with medical care and recovery, through WCB.

In exchange, covered workers generally cannot sue their employer for a workplace injury. That is the trade-off at the heart of workers’ compensation in Canada. Workers get benefits without having to prove fault or go to court. Employers pay into the system and are generally protected from lawsuits over workplace injuries. For a small business, where one lawsuit could be a serious threat, being properly covered is part of protecting the business, not just a box to tick.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a three-person house-cleaning business in Truro. One of your cleaners slips on a wet floor at a client’s home and injures her wrist. If your business is registered and she is a covered worker, she can make a claim with WCB. WCB looks at whether the injury arose from her work and, if it did, handles her benefits. You report the injury, co-operate with WCB, and work with her on getting back to work when she is ready.

Employers fund the system through assessments, which is WCB’s word for premiums. Workers do not pay into WCB, so WCB costs should not come off a worker’s pay. If you are not sure how to record WCB costs in your books, ask your bookkeeper.

WCB and workplace safety are different things

In Nova Scotia, two different bodies handle two different jobs.

WCB Nova Scotia runs the insurance side. It registers employers, sets and collects assessments, receives injury reports, decides claims, pays benefits, and supports return to work. It also runs injury prevention and education programs.

The Province of Nova Scotia runs the safety enforcement side. Workplace safety rules come from the Occupational Health and Safety Act (Nova Scotia) and its regulations. The provincial department responsible for workplace safety enforces those rules, including through inspections.

Question	Who handles it
Do I need workers’ compensation coverage?	WCB Nova Scotia
How much do I pay for coverage?	WCB Nova Scotia

Question	Who handles it
Where do I report a workplace injury for a claim?	WCB Nova Scotia
What safety rules must my workplace follow?	Province of Nova Scotia
Who inspects workplaces and enforces safety rules?	Province of Nova Scotia

Some serious incidents may also need to be reported to the provincial safety regulator, separately from your WCB report. The province sets which incidents and how quickly. Check novascotia.ca so you know the rules before you need them.

WATCH OUT

Being registered with WCB does not mean your workplace meets safety law, and meeting safety law does not register you with WCB. They are separate obligations.

Three words you will see often:

Term	What it means here
Assessment	What WCB calls the premium an employer pays
Assessable payroll	The worker earnings WCB counts for your assessment
Rate group	Industries with similar injury costs that share a rate

KEY POINTS

- WCB Nova Scotia provides no-fault workplace injury insurance.
- Covered workers generally cannot sue their employer for a workplace injury; that is the trade-off.
- Employers pay assessments. Workers do not pay into WCB.
- Workplace safety rules are a separate provincial responsibility under the Occupational Health and Safety Act.

Registration and coverage

The first question to answer is “do I need to register?” The short answer: it depends on your industry and how many workers you have at the same time. The long answer has edge cases, and WCB is the one who decides.

> NOTE
>
> Not legal advice. Use this chapter to understand the questions WCB will ask, then confirm your own situation with WCB Nova Scotia before you decide not to register.

The general rule

At the time of writing, WCB coverage is mandatory for businesses in the industries WCB lists as mandatory once they have **three or more workers at the same time**, with some exceptions set by WCB. If you meet those conditions, you need to register with WCB **within 10 days**. Confirm the current rule at wcb.ns.ca.

There are two parts to that test.

1. **Your industry.** WCB keeps a list of industries where coverage is mandatory. Some industries are not covered by the mandatory rules. Check where your business fits on WCB’s list.
2. **Your worker count.** The test is about how many workers you have *at the same time*, not how many people you hired over the whole year. Think about the busiest moment of your year.

> EXAMPLE
>
> Say you run a landscaping business in Kentville. For most of the year it is you and one employee. In May you hire two seasonal workers for the spring rush, so for six weeks you have three workers besides yourself. That busy stretch may be enough to bring you into the mandatory rules, even though you have one employee the rest of the year. This is exactly the kind of situation to check with WCB before the season starts.

Who counts as a worker?

Whether a person counts as a “worker” for WCB purposes is a question for WCB, not for you to decide alone. Raise these situations with WCB: part-time and casual staff; seasonal workers; family members who work in the business, paid or unpaid; owners, partners, and company directors; people you call “contractors” or pay by invoice; and students, trainees, and short-term helpers.

Calling someone a contractor does not settle the question. WCB may look at the real working relationship. (The Canada Revenue Agency has its own separate employee-or-contractor test for payroll. The questions are related, but the answers can differ.) The “Do I need to register?” work-

sheet in the templates chapter helps you list everyone so you can have a clear conversation with WCB.

Two or fewer workers, and out-of-province firms

At the time of writing, businesses with two or fewer workers are generally not required to register, but they can apply for **voluntary coverage**. Voluntary coverage gives your workers access to WCB benefits if they are hurt at work and brings the no-fault protection to your business. Whether it makes sense depends on your work, your risks, and your budget. A crew that climbs ladders, drives, lifts, or uses power tools faces different risks from a home-based bookkeeping practice. Ask WCB what voluntary coverage would include and cost for your industry. If you are weighing it against private insurance, an insurance broker can explain those options.

If your business is based in another province and sends workers into Nova Scotia, you may need coverage here too. At the time of writing, out-of-province firms generally need coverage if they have three or more workers in Nova Scotia for five or more days in a year. Confirm with WCB Nova Scotia and with your home province's board. If you are a Nova Scotia business sending workers to a job in New Brunswick or Prince Edward Island, ask both boards what applies.

> **TIP**
>
> If your worker count is close to the threshold, or changes with the seasons, call WCB before your busy season rather than after it. Then you know where you stand before the 10-day clock could start.

How registering works

Registration is done with WCB Nova Scotia and, at the time of writing, can be started online through wcb.ns.ca. Expect to provide your legal and operating business names, your business structure (sole proprietor, partnership, or corporation), contact details, a plain description of what your business actually does, the date you first had workers or met the mandatory conditions, and an estimate of your payroll for the year.

Describe your work accurately. The description affects how WCB classifies your business, which affects your rate. If you do more than one kind of work, say so. If you think you should have registered earlier, contact WCB now and ask what you need to do to bring your account up to date.

Registration is not a one-time event. Tell WCB when your business changes: you start a new kind of work, open a new location, add or lose workers, change your business structure (for example, you incorporate), sell the business, or close it. Each of these can affect your classification, your payroll reports, or whether you still need coverage. Write the date and the name of the person you spoke with on your call log.

Owners are not automatically covered

It is easy to assume that once the business is registered, everyone in it is covered, including themselves. At the time of writing, owners, proprietors, and partners are generally not automatically covered as workers. If you, the owner, fall off a ladder on a job, you may not have WCB benefits unless you have arranged **personal coverage**, which WCB offers for purchase. Ask WCB whether it is available for your business structure, how the coverage level is chosen, what it costs for your industry, and when it starts.

If your business is incorporated, being a director or shareholder can change the answer. Family members who work in the business can also be treated differently from an unrelated employee. These are classic edge cases. Call WCB with the details.

Whether to buy personal coverage is a personal financial decision as much as a business one. Ask yourself how you would manage if you could not work for several months, whether any private disability insurance you have excludes workplace injuries, and how physical your own work is. An insurance broker can help you compare options.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you and your sister run a small catering business in Lunenburg as partners, with one part-time server. Before wedding season, you call WCB to ask whether the business needs to register once you add two more servers, and whether personal coverage for the two of you is available. You note the date, the name of the person you spoke with, and what they said.

Hiring contractors and subcontractors

At the time of writing, if you hire a contractor who is not covered by WCB and their workers are hurt on your job, you may be responsible for their coverage. Confirm how this applies to you with WCB Nova Scotia.

In Nova Scotia you can ask a contractor for proof that they are in good standing with WCB, and WCB offers a way to check or confirm an account's status. In practice:

1. Ask the contractor for proof of WCB good standing before work starts.
2. Check that proof with WCB, using the method WCB describes on its website.
3. Keep a copy in your job file, with the date you checked.
4. On longer jobs, check again during the job and before final payment. Status can change.

One-person contractors with no workers may be treated differently from a contractor with a crew. Ask WCB how to handle them. You may also find it useful to add a clause to subcontract agreements requiring WCB coverage where required and proof of good standing on request. A lawyer can help with the wording.

If you work as a subcontractor yourself, expect general contractors and larger clients to ask you for proof of good standing. Keep your own WCB account details handy so you can answer quickly.

WATCH OUT

“Oh yes, we’re covered” is not proof. Ask, check with WCB, and file it.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a small renovation company in Amherst and hire a two-person drywall company for a basement job. Before they start, you ask for proof of WCB good standing, check it with WCB, and file a copy in the job folder with the date. Three weeks later, before releasing the final payment, you check again and file the second record.

KEY POINTS

- At the time of writing, coverage is mandatory in WCB’s mandatory industries once you have three or more workers at the same time. Register within 10 days. Confirm at wcb.ns.ca.
- Two or fewer workers: generally not required, but voluntary coverage is available.
- Who counts as a worker is WCB’s call. Bring a clear list and ask.
- Owners are generally not automatically covered. Personal coverage can be purchased.
- Check every contractor’s WCB good standing before work starts, and keep the proof.

Assessments, payroll, and MyAccount

You do not need to master WCB's rate-setting. You do need to understand the moving parts, so your payroll reports are accurate and your costs make sense.

> **NOTE**
>
> This chapter explains concepts only. It does not give rates or dollar limits, because they change every year. Look up your current figures in MyAccount or at wcb.ns.ca.

How your assessment is calculated

At the time of writing, WCB Nova Scotia calculates assessments per $100 of assessable payroll. In concept:

Your industry rate (per $100 of assessable payroll) × **your assessable payroll** ÷ 100 = **your assessment**.

Industry classification. WCB classifies each business by the kind of work it does and places it in a rate group with a rate. A roofing company and an accounting office pay different rates. If your work changes, for example a landscaper who adds snow removal, tell WCB. If you think you have been classified incorrectly, ask WCB how classifications are reviewed.

Assessable payroll. Broadly, the earnings you pay to covered workers that WCB counts for assessment. WCB sets what counts, so do not assume it matches your T4 slips line for line. Check WCB's guidance.

Maximum assessable earnings. There is a yearly cap on how much of each worker's earnings is assessable. If a worker earns more than the cap, you generally pay assessments only on earnings up to the cap. The figure changes every year, so look it up each year.

Experience rating. WCB can adjust an employer's rate up or down based on its own claims history compared to others in its industry. Ask WCB whether and how this applies to a business your size. Preventing injuries and supporting a safe return to work can matter for your costs over time, as well as for your people.

> **EXAMPLE**
>
> Say you run a small painting company in Sydney with three workers, and your estimated assessable payroll for the year is $120,000.00 (a made-up number). To estimate your assessment, you look up the current rate for your industry in MyAccount, multiply it by 1,200 (that is, $120,000.00 divided by $100), and adjust for anyone earning above the maximum assessable earnings. You never use a rate from an old notice or this guide.

Estimates and actuals

At the time of writing, employers report payroll to WCB in two forms. You give an **estimate** of assessable payroll for the coming year, which WCB uses to bill you. Later you report your **actual** assessable payroll, and WCB reconciles the difference. If your estimate was too low, you may owe more. If it was too high, the difference may be credited. How often you pay and report, and the due dates, depend on your account, so check MyAccount.

A low estimate only moves the bill to later, and a high one ties up cash. Base your estimate on real plans: if you are hiring two summer workers, include them. If your payroll changes a lot during the year, ask WCB how to update your estimate. It helps to set up your payroll software or spreadsheet so you can see each worker's earnings for the year at a glance; that makes both the estimate and the actual report quicker.

Using MyAccount

MyAccount is WCB Nova Scotia's online portal for employers. At the time of writing, you can use it to report payroll, view your account, make payments, and file injury reports. Features change, so follow WCB's current instructions. A few habits help:

- Keep the login in a password manager, and remove access when someone leaves.
- Make sure the email address on file is one someone actually reads.
- Copy every due date from MyAccount into your calendar, and save each payment confirmation.
- If you cannot pay on time, contact WCB before the due date to ask about options.

KEY POINTS

- Assessments are based on your industry rate and assessable payroll, per $100 of payroll.
- A yearly cap applies per worker, and experience rating can adjust your rate.
- You report an estimate, then actual payroll, and WCB reconciles the two.
- Get every rate, limit, and due date from MyAccount or wcb.ns.ca.

When a worker gets hurt

Reading this chapter before you need it makes it far easier to do the right things in the right order. The injury-response checklist and incident notes form in the templates chapter turn it into something you can post on the wall and keep in the truck.

Step 1: Take care of the person

Make the area safe so nobody else is hurt. Give first aid if someone present is trained to. If the injury is serious, call 911. If the worker needs care beyond first aid, help them get it, and arrange a ride if they should not drive. Stay calm. This is not the moment to argue about fault.

> **WATCH OUT**
>
> Never discourage a worker from getting medical care or from reporting an injury. Apart from the harm to the worker, it can create serious problems for your business. If you are unsure of your obligations, ask WCB.

Step 2: Write down what happened

As soon as the worker is looked after, start your notes while details are fresh, using the incident notes form. Record the date, time, and exact location; what the worker was doing; what happened, in plain factual words; the body part hurt, as the worker describes it; who saw it; what first aid or medical care was given; and what you did to make the area safe.

Stick to facts. Write “Worker said she slipped on wet tile in client’s kitchen,” not “Worker was careless.” Take photos if appropriate, and set aside any tool involved until it has been checked.

Step 3: Decide whether you must report

At the time of writing, employers must report a workplace injury to WCB when it **results in lost time beyond the day of injury** or **needs medical treatment beyond first aid**.

A small cut cleaned and bandaged on site, with the worker back at work the same day, may not need a WCB report. A worker who sees a doctor, or who misses work the next day, generally does. When in doubt, call WCB and ask. Asking is better than missing a deadline.

> **NOTE**
>
> Not legal advice. Whether a particular injury must be reported is a question for WCB Nova Scotia. If you are unsure, ask.

Step 4: Report on time

At the time of writing WCB Nova Scotia says to report an injury **within two business days** of becoming aware of it. Confirm on wcb.ns.ca. This timeline was shortened from five business days, and some of WCB's older pages may still say five. Go by the current guidance on WCB's MyAccount forms page, not an old printout.

Reports are filed through **MyAccount** or with WCB's **Injury Report** form. Have your incident notes in front of you so your answers are accurate and consistent.

> **TIP**
>
> Do not wait for a doctor's note, a full investigation, or the worker's own paperwork before you report. Report what you know within the deadline, and update WCB if you learn more.

Step 5: Support the worker and co-operate with WCB

Your worker also has a part to play. They should tell you about an injury as soon as they can, and they may need to give information to WCB directly. WCB's website explains the worker's steps. Give the worker WCB's contact information and let them know you will support them. Your job is to report accurately, answer WCB's questions honestly, and treat the worker fairly.

WCB may contact you about the incident, the worker's job and earnings, or available work. Respond promptly, and log every contact: the date, the person you spoke with, and what was discussed. If you disagree with a WCB decision, ask WCB about its review process.

Injury information includes personal health information. Collect only what you need, keep it secure and separate from general files, and share it only with people who need to know.

> **KEY POINTS**
>
> - Look after the injured worker first, then write factual notes.
> - Report injuries that cause lost time beyond the day of injury or need treatment beyond first aid.
> - At the time of writing WCB Nova Scotia says two business days. Confirm on wcb.ns.ca.
> - Co-operate with WCB, log every contact, and protect the worker's privacy.

Return to work

At the time of writing, employers and workers in Nova Scotia both have duties to co-operate in a worker's early and safe return to work after an injury. A good return-to-work process keeps a trained person connected to the team and can matter for your WCB costs over time. Above all, it is the decent way to treat someone who was hurt working for you.

Keep in regular, respectful contact. Let the worker know you want them back when it is safe. Do not pressure them to come back early, and do not ask for medical details beyond what you need to plan suitable work.

Modified duties

"Modified duties" means adjusting a worker's job so they can do safe, productive work while they recover. It might mean lighter tasks, shorter hours, a different schedule, or the same tasks with help or different equipment. Modified duties should fit what the worker can safely do right now, as described by their health care provider and WCB, and they should be real work, not busywork.

EXAMPLE

Say you run a landscaping company in Wolfville, and one of your crew strains his back. His health care provider says no heavy lifting for a few weeks. While he recovers, he does light equipment maintenance and calls clients to schedule fall clean-ups. As he improves, you add more of his usual tasks.

A small business does not have many "light" jobs, so make a list now, before anyone is hurt: scheduling, ordering supplies, quality checks, customer calls. When it is time to plan a return, use the return-to-work outline in the templates chapter. Write down what you agree, give the worker a copy, and keep WCB informed, especially if the worker cannot manage the agreed duties. Return-to-work duties are set by law and WCB policy, and this is not legal advice. If you are unsure what is required of you, ask WCB Nova Scotia.

KEY POINTS

- Employers and workers both have duties to co-operate in an early and safe return to work.
- Stay in respectful contact without pressuring the worker.
- Modified duties should match current abilities and be real work. List them now.

Prevention, records, and common mistakes

Preventing injuries

Prevention protects your people first, and over time it can help with costs too. Workplace safety in Nova Scotia is governed by the Occupational Health and Safety Act and its regulations, enforced by the province. Small employers still have safety duties, and some requirements, such as written policies, depend on the size of your workforce. Check novascotia.ca for what applies to a business your size.

> NOTE
>
> Not legal advice. These are practical habits, not a list of your legal safety obligations. Check the Occupational Health and Safety Act and its regulations at novascotia.ca.

You do not need a binder full of procedures to make a real difference:

- **Walk through your work.** For each task, ask what could go wrong: lifting, ladders, slippery floors, sharp tools, chemicals, driving, working alone, heat or cold.
- **Fix the easy things now.** A proper step ladder instead of a chair, a cart for heavy loads, non-slip mats, labelled chemical bottles, better lighting.
- **Provide and require the right gear,** whatever your work calls for.
- **Talk about safety often.** A five-minute chat at the start of a job about today's hazards keeps safety visible.
- **Make it easy to speak up.** Thank people who report hazards and near misses.
- **Plan for working alone,** with agreed check-in times.
- **Write a short safety policy** in plain language and go over it with each new person on day one.
- **Train before people work alone,** and record who was trained, on what, when, and by whom.

WCB Nova Scotia runs safety and prevention programs, including WorkSafe for Life. Visit wcb.ns.ca and look for the prevention resources. Industry associations in Nova Scotia may also offer training for your sector.

Records to keep

Good records make every WCB task easier. Keep these in one place, paper or digital: your WCB account details; every payroll estimate and actual report; assessment notices and payment confirmations; notes from every call with WCB; contractor proof of good standing with the dates checked; incident notes, injury reports, and claim correspondence (stored securely); return-to-work plans; safety training records and your safety policy; and details of any personal coverage.

CRA generally requires you to keep books and records for six years from the end of the last tax year they relate to (confirm at canada.ca/revenue-agency). For WCB and safety records, ask WCB and check the provincial rules before you dispose of anything.

Common mistakes

- **Assuming you are too small.** The test is about industry and workers at the same time. Seasonal peaks count.
- **Assuming you are covered.** Registering the business does not automatically cover you as the owner.
- **Guessing who counts as a worker.** Family members, part-timers, and "contractors" are questions for WCB.
- **Using an old rate or deadline.** Rates, limits, and even the injury reporting timeline change. At the time of writing, WCB had shortened reporting from five business days to two (confirm on wcb.ns.ca).
- **Underestimating payroll.** It only moves the bill to later.
- **Not checking contractors.** Ask, check with WCB, and file the proof.
- **Waiting to report an injury.** Waiting for a doctor's note can mean missing the deadline.
- **Discouraging a claim.** Hinting that a worker should not report an injury, or should "just use a sick day," harms the worker and can create serious problems for you.
- **Not telling WCB when your business changes.** New kinds of work, a big change in payroll, or closing the business all need a call to WCB.

KEY POINTS

- Safety law is provincial. Check what applies to you at novascotia.ca, then find and fix hazards.
- Keep all WCB, payroll, contractor, injury, and training records together.
- Most mistakes come from assuming. When in doubt, ask WCB.

Templates and worksheets

Print these, copy them into a document, or rebuild them in a spreadsheet. They help you organize information. They do not decide anything for you. Confirm every decision with WCB Nova Scotia.

Worksheet: Do I need to register?

WORKSHEET

What my business does, in plain words: _____

Is my industry on WCB's list of mandatory industries? (check wcb.ns.ca) Yes / No / Not sure

Name	Role	Hours or schedule	Paid how?
1.			
2.			
3.			
4.			

Highest number of people working for me at the same time this year: _____

Any family members, owners, directors, or "contractors" on the list? _____

Any workers going to or coming from another province? _____

Date I called WCB, and who I spoke with: _____

What WCB told me: _____

Worksheet: Payroll estimate (no rates)

Get your industry rate and the current maximum assessable earnings from MyAccount or wcb.ns.ca.

WORKSHEET

Worker	Expected earnings this year	Above the yearly cap?	Assessable amount
	$		$
	$		$
	$		$

Worker	Expected earnings this year	Above the yearly cap?	Assessable amount
	$		$

Total estimated assessable payroll: $_____

Current maximum assessable earnings (from WCB): $_____

My industry rate per $100 (from MyAccount): _____

Estimated assessment (total assessable payroll ÷ 100 × rate): $_____

Planned hires or changes this year: _____

Checklist: Injury response

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Make the area safe; give first aid; call 911 if serious
- [ ] Help the worker get medical care if needed
- [ ] Set aside any tool or equipment involved
- [ ] Start the incident notes form; get witness names; take photos if appropriate
- [ ] Lost time beyond the day of injury, or treatment beyond first aid? If yes or unsure, report
- [ ] Report to WCB through MyAccount or the Injury Report form within the current deadline (two business days at the time of writing; confirm on wcb.ns.ca)
- [ ] Check whether the incident must also be reported to the provincial safety regulator (novascotia.ca)
- [ ] Give the worker WCB's contact information and stay in respectful contact
- [ ] Log every contact with WCB
- [ ] Fix the hazard, tell the team what changed, and store records securely

Form: Incident notes

WORKSHEET

Worker's name: _____

Date and time of incident: _____

Date I became aware of it: _____

Exact location: _____

What the worker was doing: _____

What happened (facts only): _____

Body part(s) affected, as described by the worker: _____

Witnesses (names and contact): _____

First aid or medical care given: _____

Time missed beyond the day of injury? _____

Equipment involved, and where it is now: _____

Steps taken to make the area safe: _____

Reported to WCB on (date, method): _____

Notes completed by, and date: _____

Checklist: Contractor WCB check

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Contractor's legal business name recorded
- [ ] Asked whether they have workers or work alone
- [ ] Asked for proof of WCB good standing before work starts
- [ ] Checked the proof with WCB, using the method on wcb.ns.ca
- [ ] Saved a copy in the job file with the date checked
- [ ] Agreement includes a WCB coverage clause (wording reviewed by a lawyer)
- [ ] Checked again partway through a long job and before final payment

Outline: Return-to-work conversation

TEMPLATE

Before: Review what the worker can and cannot safely do right now. List tasks that fit.

Open: "Thanks for meeting with me. How are you feeling? We want you back when it is safe, and we want to plan it together."

Abilities: "What feels manageable right now? Is there anything you have been told to avoid?"

Duties: Go through your task list together. Agree on duties, hours, and schedule.

Support: “What would make this easier? Different equipment, more breaks, help with lifting?”

Write it down: Return-to-work plan for [Worker name], starting [Date]: duties [List], hours [Hours], check-ins [Dates], review date [Date]. Give the worker a copy and let WCB know the plan.

Calendar: Annual WCB tasks

This is a generic routine. Confirm your actual due dates in MyAccount and write them in.

When	Task	My due date
Start of year	Report actual payroll for last year; file estimate for this year	
Each payment period	Pay assessment; save confirmation	
Before busy season	Count workers at the same time; call WCB if close to the threshold	
Before each job	Check contractors’ WCB good standing	
Quarterly	Compare real payroll to estimate; update WCB if it changed a lot	
Quarterly	Safety walk-through and team chat	
Yearly	Review safety policy, training records, first aid kits, owner coverage, and light-duty list	
When business changes	Tell WCB about new work, locations, or closing	

Checklist

CHECKLIST

- [ ] Checked whether my industry is on WCB's list of mandatory industries
- [ ] Counted the highest number of workers I have at the same time, including seasonal peaks
- [ ] Called WCB about any edge cases (family, part-time, owners, contractors) and logged the call
- [ ] Registered within 10 days of meeting the conditions, or decided about voluntary coverage
- [ ] Confirmed my own coverage as owner and considered personal coverage
- [ ] Confirmed my industry classification matches what my business actually does
- [ ] Filed a realistic payroll estimate and put my MyAccount due dates in my calendar
- [ ] Set up MyAccount access and decided who can use it
- [ ] Made a habit of checking every contractor's WCB good standing
- [ ] Posted the injury-response checklist where my team can see it
- [ ] Know the current injury reporting deadline (two business days at the time of writing; confirmed on wcb.ns.ca)
- [ ] Printed copies of the incident notes form
- [ ] Made a list of lighter tasks for modified duties
- [ ] Checked my safety duties under the Occupational Health and Safety Act at novascotia.ca
- [ ] Wrote a short safety policy and started recording training
- [ ] Set up one place for all WCB records, including a log of every call with WCB
- [ ] Added a WCB coverage clause to my subcontract agreements, with wording checked by a lawyer
- [ ] Checked that first aid kits are stocked and I know who has first aid training
- [ ] Added my yearly WCB routine to my calendar, with due dates taken from MyAccount
- [ ] Told WCB about any recent changes to my work, locations, structure, or payroll

Where to learn more

Official sources

- **WCB Nova Scotia** (wcb.ns.ca): registration, the list of mandatory industries, assessment rates, maximum assessable earnings, MyAccount, injury reporting, return to work, contractor good standing, owner personal coverage, and prevention resources including WorkSafe for Life.
- **Province of Nova Scotia** (novascotia.ca): the Occupational Health and Safety Act and its regulations, workplace safety requirements, and the Labour Standards Code for employment standards such as pay, hours, and vacation.
- **Canada Revenue Agency** (canada.ca/revenue-agency): payroll deductions, employee or contractor status, and record keeping.

Questions to ask when you call WCB

Have your worksheet in front of you, and write the answers down.

- Is my industry on the mandatory list, and how is my business classified?
- Based on my schedule, do the people who work for me count as workers, and do I need to register?
- If I am not required to register, what would voluntary coverage include?
- Am I covered as the owner? What would personal coverage involve?
- What counts as assessable payroll for my business, and when are my reports and payments due?
- How do I confirm a contractor's good standing?
- What is the current deadline for reporting an injury, and how do I file a report?

Talk to a professional

- **A lawyer who works with employers:** subcontract wording, your obligations, disputes.
- **An accountant or bookkeeper:** payroll set up so WCB reports are accurate.
- **An insurance broker:** WCB personal coverage compared with private insurance.
- **A safety professional or industry association:** a safety program that fits your work.

This guide is general information, not legal advice. WCB Nova Scotia decides questions about registration, classification, assessments, and claims, and its rules change. When you are unsure, call WCB, write down what they tell you, and keep the note with your records.